

see another side of the other person,” she said. My mom is a major advocate for the pre-nuptial agreement, a contract made before a wedding or civil union that includes specifics of spousal support or division of assets in the event of a separation or divorce. (Fun fact: If you decide to sign this sort of contract after you wed, that’s called a post-nuptial agreement.) A pre-nup, she said, allows each of you to remain in control of your financial lives. If you get divorced without this agreement, a judge you don’t know gets to dictate your future based on a set of laws that are often unfair and don’t take into account the particular circumstances of your life.

My mom would kill me if I ever got married without a pre-nup, but some people find them very “unromantic.” A *HuffPost* blog post from 2015, “Why You Shouldn’t Sign a Prenup,” provides maybe the most ludicrous “romantic” argument against a pre-nup I’d ever heard. The blogger wrote that “the act of getting one is by its very nature pernicious to relationships.” She claimed pre-nups encouraged couples not to try as hard to save their marriages because there are no stakes if separation is easy. In other words, having a pre-nup doesn’t incentivize the couple to stay together. This is bad advice, and I’ve heard *a lot* of bad advice. A couple’s commitment to staying together should be about more than the inconvenience of divorce, and sometimes, divorce is the best-case scenario. People use divorce to extract themselves from toxic or abusive situations, which can be made even more challenging when money is involved. (I had a friend who stayed with a cheating fiancé because she couldn’t afford to move out.) Many of the women my mom has represented were so relieved after their divorce was finalized that they invited her out for celebratory drinks.

Rockman relayed the story of a couple who spent ten horrifying years in divorce court fighting over custody specifics because they had three kids. Had they had a pre-nup in place outlining what happened if they divorced—alimony, custody, child support—they could have saved a lot of money and time. Instead, they endured years of lawyers’ fees, emotional exhaustion, court dates, and all kinds of other consequences.

Rockman says that while marriage can certainly be romantic, it is also a contract, which means that it should be approached in the same way you’d approach an auto loan or a mortgage: with serious forethought, attention to